PROGRAMMING & METHODS



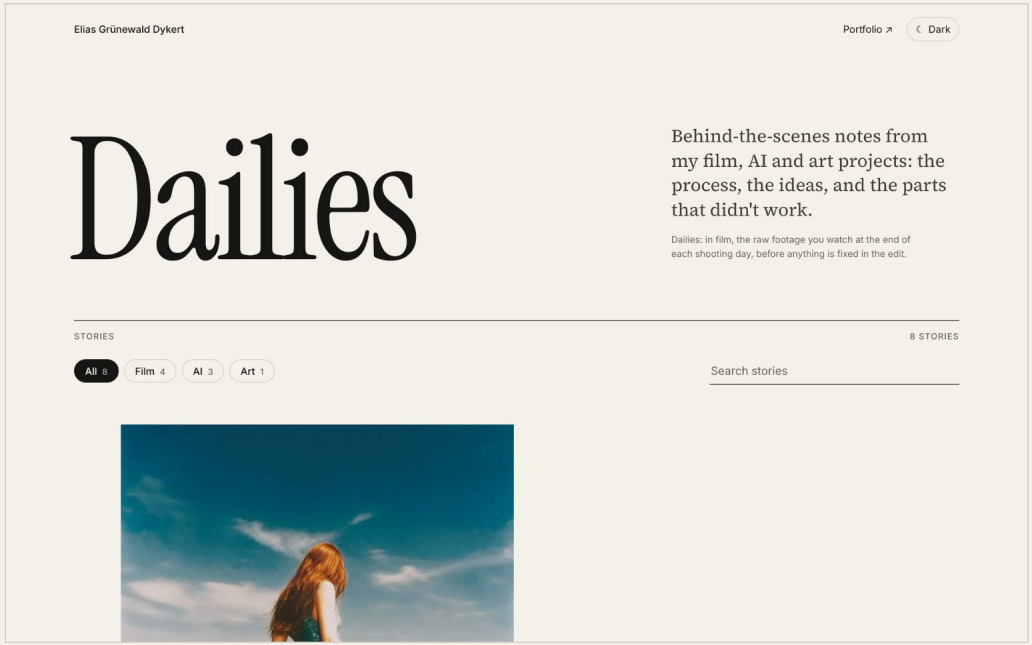


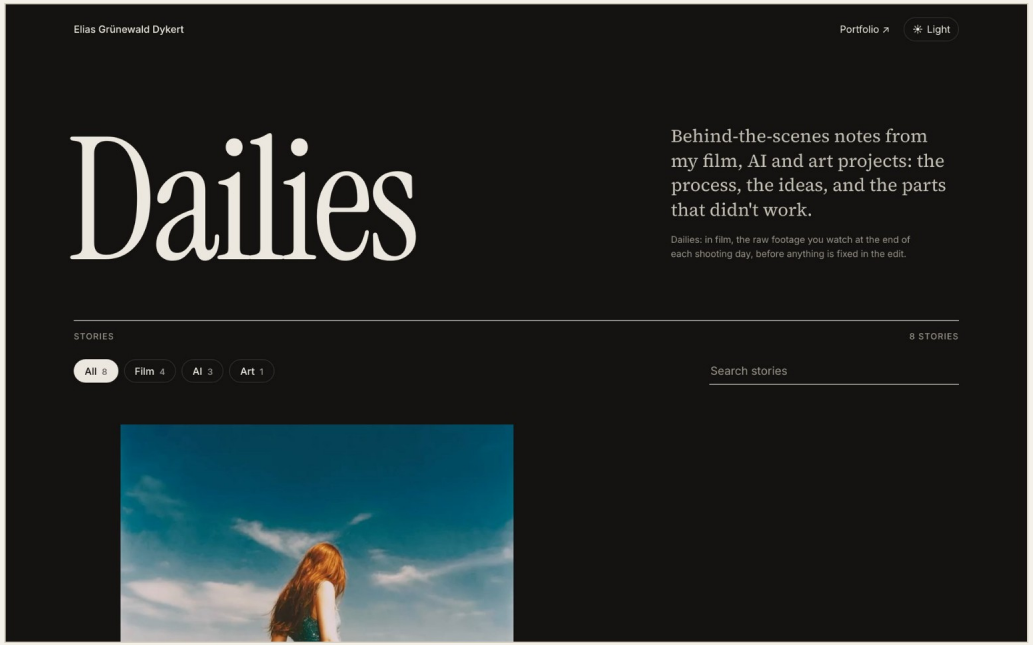
Light or dark?

Building a theme switcher for my blog, Dailies

Elias Grünewald Dykert

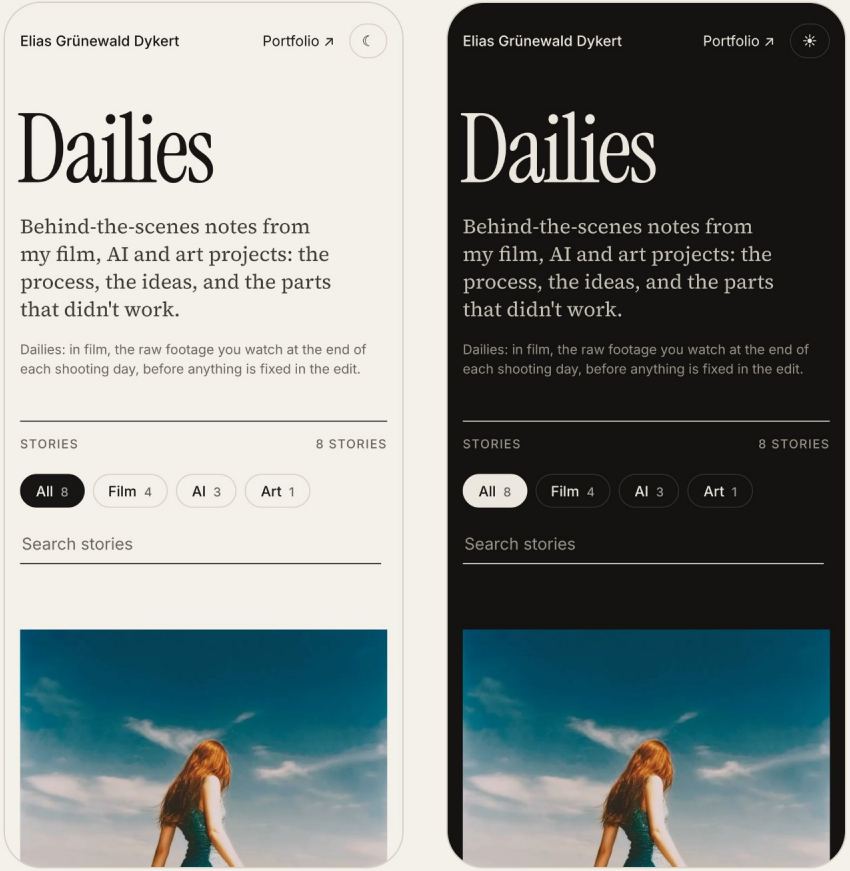
One button changes the colours





Why is it useful?

- Easier on the eyes at night
- Matches your phone or computer
- ✓ Your choice is remembered



Today you'll learn

1

How a website knows you like dark or light mode



2

How one click changes every colour



3

How the website remembers your choice



Four words to know

`CSS variable`

A name for a colour. Change it in one place, and it changes everywhere.

`prefers-color-scheme`

Your computer's light or dark setting. CSS can read it.

`localStorage`

A small notebook in the browser. It keeps your choice between visits.

`data-theme`

A label on the page: "light" or "dark".

Step by step

WHEN THE PAGE OPENS

Page opens → Is a choice saved? `localStorage` → **Yes:** use it / **No:** follow the computer `prefers-color-scheme` → Colours appear

WHEN YOU CLICK THE BUTTON

Click

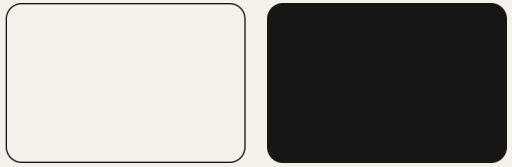


→ Change the label `data-theme` → CSS swaps the colours → Save the choice `localStorage`

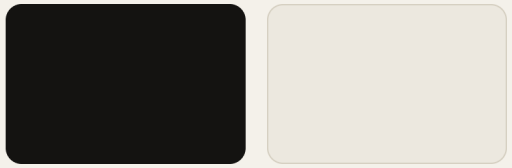
The trick: give each colour a name

```
:root {
  --paper: #f4f1ea;
  --ink: #171614;
}
:root[data-theme="dark"] {
  --paper: #141311;
  --ink: #ece8df;
}
body {
  background: var(--paper);
  color: var(--ink);
}
```

LIGHT



DARK

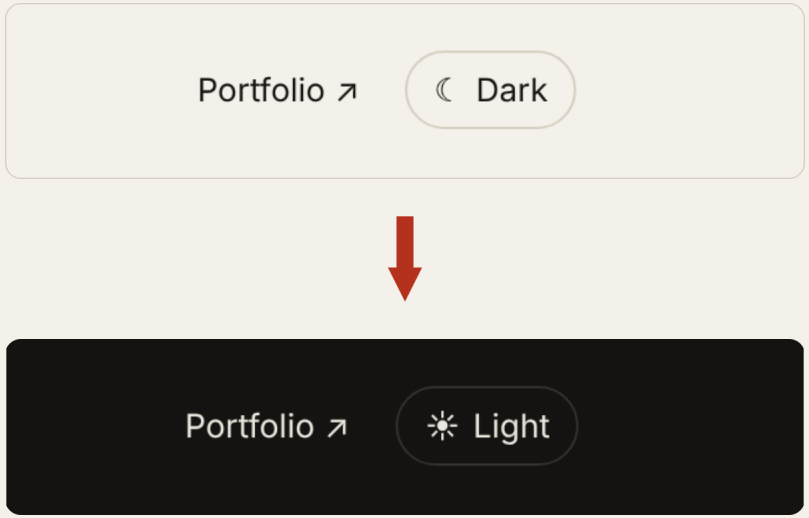


Same names, new values. The rest of the CSS doesn’t change.

The code: what the click does

public/js/theme.js

```
button.addEventListener('click', () => {
  // 1. pick the other theme
  const next = currentTheme() === 'dark'
    ? 'light' : 'dark';
  // 2. put the label on the page
  document.documentElement.dataset.theme = next;
  // 3. remember it
  saveTheme(next);
  // 4. update the button
  renderButton(button);
});
```



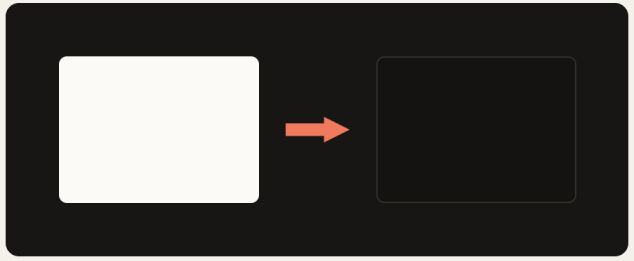
One click, four small steps

The Prompt

> *“Add a light and dark theme switcher. Make it so it follows my preferred settings, make it so it prefers visitors own settings. I want the button on the header on every page, top right. If it can remember a visitors choice, that would be dope too. Match the colours we already established on the website.”*

- My documentation: Claude’s explanations
- Tested light, dark and phone.

Three problems Claude Code spotted and fixed



A white flash when the page loads

Fix: a tiny script in the <head> sets the theme before the page is drawn.

```
try {
  localStorage.setItem(…)
} catch {}
```

Private windows can block localStorage

Fix: try / catch. If saving fails, the button still works.

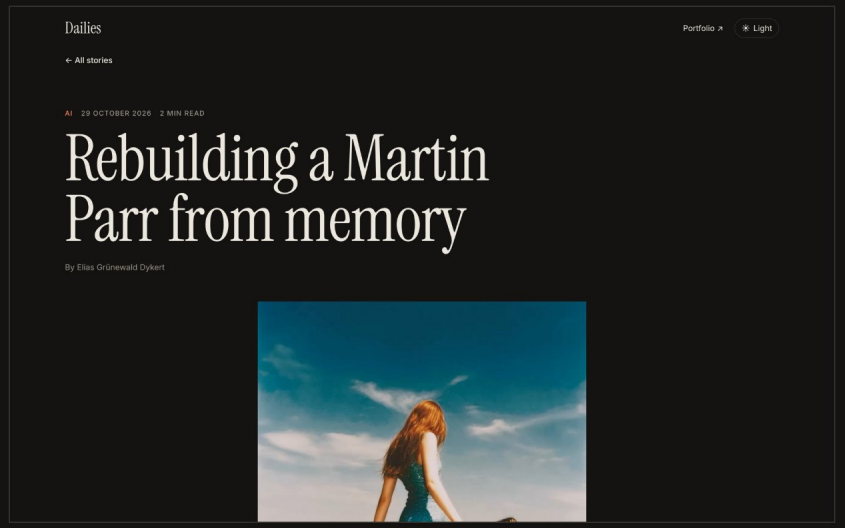


My red was too dark in dark mode

Fix: a lighter red, only for the dark theme.

Three things to remember

1. Give colours names. Swap the values, and the site changes.
2. Follow the computer first. The button lets you choose.
3. Save the choice, and load it before the page is drawn.



Questions?